resilient supply chains, infrastructure and clean energy. As the world embraces the goal of carbon neutrality, the launch of the India-Japan Clean Energy Partnership harbours enormous scope for collaboration in the production of electric vehicles, batteries, charging infrastructure, solar technology, hydrogen and ammonia.

The Memorandum of Cooperation (MoC) in cybersecurity and ICT (information and communications technology) will advance information-sharing and capacity-building in a digital era characterised by new challenges in 5G, Open RAN, telecom network security, submarine cable systems and quantum communications. Highly skilled Indian IT professionals will also be able to work in Japan in the ICT sector, adding to the success of the Specified Skilled Worker (SSW) track.

THE TIES THAT BIND

- On a visit to India in 2014, then Japan PM Shinzo Abe announced a target of 3.5 trillion Yen (**Rs 2.2 lakh crore**) for Japanese investment and financing in India over five years
- On his visit over March 19-20 this year, PM Fumio Kishida announced an increase in Japan's investment and financing target to 5 trillion Yen (**Rs 3.2 lakh crore**) over the next five years
- Auto major Suzuki's contribution to Japan's investments in India is a planned 150 billion Yen (**Rs 9,450 crore**) in the production of electric vehicles and batteries
- Bilateral trade in 2020 amounted to $1.17 trillion (**Rs 89 lakh crore**) ($363 billion/ Rs 27.6 lakh crore in Indian exports, $807 billion/ Rs 61.4 lakh crore in imports)

It is evident that the joint statement has succeeded in sending a strong signal to stakeholders in Japan to make renewed efforts to deepen economic and investment ties with India. The shared intention to realise JPY 5 trillion (approximately $42 billion or Rs 3.2 lakh crore) of public and private investment and financing from Japan to India over the next five years is a measure of the confidence on both sides in the future of the partnership.

Japanese technology has proved to be a game-changer in India's modernisation in many sectors, including the automotive industry. High-speed rail is another such example. In a country increasingly stressed by water scarcity and the scourge of waste water effluents, the MoC on Decentralised Domestic Wastewater Management will introduce Japan's Johkasou technology to boost sewage treatment and recycling infrastructure in India.

The outlining of the India-Japan Industrial Competitiveness Partnership (IJICP) Roadmap during the summit should also help improve manufacturing standards in India in the MSME sector, which accounts for a large chunk of exports.

The Modi government has successfully engaged Japan in reviewing certain aspects of the India-Japan Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) pertaining to Indian exports of fish *surimi* (fish paste). The decision to hold the inaugural fighter exercise between the Japan Air Self-Defence Force and the Indian Air Force, coming on the back of existing naval and ground forces cooperation, will deepen mutual trust and advance interoperability.

INDIA FIGURES PROMINENTLY AS AN ALTERNATIVE INVESTMENT DESTINATION IN JAPAN'S "CHINA PLUS" MODEL OF RISK MITIGATION

The strength of the India-Japan partnership cannot arbitrarily be benchmarked to geopolitical issues rocking the world, whether in Ukraine or elsewhere. The Quad, in any case, is not a Europe-centric construct. India and Japan have acknowledged in the joint statement their commitment to a peaceful, stable and prosperous world supported by a rules-based order, with respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity and the peaceful resolution of disputes at the core. The rejection of the threat or use of force to alter status quo hints at China's unilateralism and military coercion across the Indo-Pacific.

Kishida's visit provided a much-awaited opportunity for the prime ministers of India and Japan to engage in a face-to-face meeting ahead of the Quad Leaders' Summit to be held in Tokyo later this summer. Japan is making purposeful efforts to adopt a "China Plus" model as part of a broader risk mitigation strategy. India figures prominently as an alternative destination for Japanese investments. ■

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